partly in the effect of relative cultural values, the Chinese being long seen – for purposes of this comparison – as 'closer' – pragmatic, down-to-earth, hardheaded – and the Indians, or more particularly, the Hindus, as much more exotic, much more violently different, as indeed Hindu culture is from Anglo-Protestant and most other forms of Western culture.'[39]

Isaacs' study was of American views of India and China. But many would testify that these images exist in varying degrees in other societies around the world. This is not surprising. The Western media, particularly the American, and Western publishing more broadly, has played an enormous role. Perhaps the single most damning book on India over the past one hundred years was the American Katherine Mayo's 1927 book, *Mother India*, which was so critical of Indian society that Mahatma Gandhi was moved to call it 'the report of a drain inspector'. On the other hand, influential Westerners in political, social, and economic life constantly reinforce the image of the pragmatic, civic-minded Chinese. Ironically, Indians, particularly educated middle-class Indians, have their own version of the image: the Chinese are prepared to take 'hard decisions' and make sacrifices for the collective good while Indians are prone to choose 'soft options' and selfishly pursue their own advancement. Whether these images are 'true' is not the point. They exist, and they colour the view foreigners, Indians, and Chinese have of the two societies.

Over the past two decades, China has appeared in a related guise: as an international, global, and secular setting, particularly in its big cities. Beijing, Shanghai, Chongqing, Tianjin, Guangzhou, and Shenzhen feel like modern, perhaps even ultra-modern, metropolises: if one forgets the Chinese faces on the streets, they could be located on any continent. India never feels like that. It feels very national and local, with religiosity conspicuously on display in its many places of worship, religious processions, and other public marks of faith. Its cities are a mix of civic amenities that could be simultaneously of the nineteenth, twentieth, and twenty-first centuries: they have a distinctly South Asian look and feel. Indian cities have their own attractions, but they are not those of Prada-lined global cities. Not surprisingly, foreigners of all kinds flock to China –